to show the Home government the error of its ways. Little by little through the early 1920s London would be forced to adapt its policies towards Tehran, Kabul and Moscow, until by 1923 things would stand much closer to what the Indian government had advocated in 1918.

The Foreign Office

The creation of British foreign policy in the twentieth century was a complex business. While it may be presumed that the foreign secretary is always responsible for the direction of foreign policy, many have argued that in the post-First World War period the Foreign Office lost its privileged position within the British government. The idea that 'the Foreign Office lacked the influence over British foreign policy that it had exercised before the outbreak of the Great War' is commonplace in the historiography of this topic.[10] Others have taken this further and argued that the Foreign Office was all but ignored until the mid-1920s.[11] The exclusion of Arthur Balfour (Foreign Secretary from December 1916 until October 1919) from Lloyd George's War Cabinet is one such example of the Foreign Office being edged out of government decision-making.[12] Even following the conclusion of the conflict, Balfour did not make an effort to exert his position: during the Paris Peace Conference, Curzon complained that Balfour 'did not know, was not told, and was as a rule too careless to inquire, what was going on'.[13]

In 1919, contemporaries hoped that Curzon's arrival at the Foreign Office would stem its loss of influence. Yet clashes between Curzon and Lloyd George were commonplace, the prime minister feeling particular animus towards his foreign secretary, teasing him publicly on his pompous manner.[14] However, more troublesome for the Foreign Office than this personality clash was Lloyd George's inherent dislike of traditional diplomacy in general. Believing that 'diplomatists were invented simply to waste time' the prime minister was happy to evade the Foreign Office when it came to matters of foreign affairs as frequently as he could get away with.[15] Indeed, Lloyd George's distrust of the officials of the Foreign Office was demonstrated by his creation of the Prime Minister's Secretariat, otherwise known as the notorious 'Garden Suburb' – staff housed in a